

between 98.5% and 1%, “God” versus “who”. It is hard to imagine any possible set of circumstances in the transmissional history sufficient to produce the cataclysmic overthrow in statistical probability required by the claim that “who” is the original reading.

It really does seem that those scholars who reject the Majority Text are faced with a serious problem. How is it to be explained if it does not reflect the Original? Hort’s notion of a Lucianic revision has been abandoned by most scholars because of the total lack of historical evidence. The eclecticists are not even trying. The “process” view has not been articulated in sufficient detail to permit refutation, but on the face of it that view is flatly contradicted by the argument from statistical probability.¹ How could any amount of ‘process’ bridge the gap between B or Aleph and the TR?

third century there seem to be clear references in Hippolytus, “*Θεος εν σωματι εφανερωθη*” (*Contra Haeresim Noeti*, c. xvii), Dionysius, “*Θεος γαρ εφανερωθη εν σαρκι*” (*Concilia*, i. 853a) and Gregory Thaumaturgus, “*και εστιν Θεος αληθινος ο ασαρκος εν σαρκι φανερωθεις*” (quoted by Photius). In the 4th century there are clear quotes or references in Gregory of Nyssa (22 times), Gregory of Nazianzus, Didymus of Alexandria, Diodorus, the Apostolic Constitutions, and Chrysostom, followed by Cyril of Alexandria, Theodoret, and Euthalius in the fifth century, and so on (Burgon, *Ibid.*, pp. 456-76, 486-90).

As for the grammatically aberrant reading, “who”, aside from the MSS already cited, the earliest version that clearly supports it is the gothic (fourth century). To get a clear Greek Patristic witness to this reading pretty well requires the sequence *μυστηριον ος εφανερωθη*, since after any reference to Christ, Savior, Son of God, etc. in the prior context the use of a relative clause is predictable. Burgon affirmed that he was aware of no such testimony (and his knowledge of the subject has probably never been equaled) (*Ibid.*, p. 483). It thus appears that the “Western” and “Byzantine” readings have earlier attestation than does the “Alexandrian”. Yet if “which” was caused by “who”, then the latter must be older. The reading “who” is admittedly the most difficult, so much so that to apply the “harder reading” canon in the face of an easy transcriptional explanation [the accidental omission of the two strokes of the pen] for the difficult reading seems unreasonable. As Burgon so well put it:

I trust we are at least agreed that the maxim “*proclivi lectioni praestat ardua*,” does not enunciate so foolish a proposition as that in choosing between two or more conflicting readings, we are to prefer **that** one which has the feeblest external attestation,—provided it be but in itself almost unintelligible? (*Ibid.*, p. 497).

Whatever the intention of those editors who choose ‘who’, their text emasculates this strong statement of the deity of Jesus Christ, besides being a stupidity—what is a ‘mystery’ about any human male being manifested in flesh? All human beings have bodies. In the Greek Text the relative pronoun has no antecedent, so it is a grammatical ‘impossibility’.

¹ For further discussion see the final pages of Appendix C in my *Identity IV*.